

MANDAR DEODHAR

234,000
Ganesh idols immersed in Mumbai in 2024; over 200,000 of these were made of PoP

80
PER CENT
Proportion of PoP idols made in Pen taluka; rest are of clay

THE PoP PREDICAMENT

PROS
- Quick to mould and dry
- Idols are lighter but sturdier than those made of clay
- Cheaper and easy to transport

CONS
- Non-biodegradable, unlike clay idols
- Leach toxic paints, harmful to aquatic life

HUBBUB AT THE HUB

For decades, idol-making has been the lifeblood of Hamrapur and neighbouring villages like Kalave, Johe, Tambadshet and Dadar in Pen taluka of Raigad district. Anchored by Pen town, the region is the nucleus of Maharashtra's Ganesh idol industry and even got the Geographical Indication (GI) tag in 2023. Across the taluka, some 250,000 people are said to be employed in the Rs 200-crore industry, collectively shipping out millions of clay and PoP idols each year, not only in India but to diaspora communities as far afield as the United States. Mumbai alone hosts some 12,000 public Ganesh mandals and over 200,000 household idols—most of them made from PoP and sourced from this region.

Historically, Ganesh worship in Maharashtra was a modest, private ritual, with small, hand-crafted idols made from local clay. But in the 1890s, nationalist leader Bal Gangadhar Tilak elevated the festival into a public spectacle—an instrument of anti-colonial solidarity. Pen's transformation into an idol-making hub gathered pace in the 1950s, propelled by its location between Mumbai and Pune, and the availability of clay. A crucial shift came when local sculptor N.G. 'Rajabhau' Deodhar experimented with PoP, initially to embellish decorative images with finer detailing. Cultural cues added fuel. In V. Shantaram's 1959 film *Navrang*, an imposing 11-foot Ganesh idol made of PoP commanded the screen and was later immersed ceremo-